

# Project Proposal

infrared.city-1: Tree detection

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March 26, 2026

# 1 Project Description

This chapter outlines the motivation, methods used, data sources and the scope of this project.

## 1.1 Motivation and Project Overview

As urban areas are expanding and global temperatures rise due to climate change, being able to understand how trees can help cool cities has become increasingly important [1]. Furthermore, trees reduce the risk of flooding in cities and promote health and wellbeing [2]. Our project aims at taking the first step in the direction of better tree coverage in urban areas by creating a model which is able to predict tree locations using satellite imagery of densely populated areas.

There is a recently very fast growing body of research on urban tree detection using deep learning models. One of the most recent papers is by Gong et al. [3], they use satellite data not only to detect trees but also to estimate their size and density. For that they use a slightly different model than the U-Net model used in this paper.

## 1.2 Data Sources

For our project we use publicly available Sentinel-2 satellite images with 10-meter spatial resolution and four color channels, namely red, green, blue and near infrared. The images are retrieved via the API of the Copernicus Programme and are provided by the European Space Agency [4]. As seasonality has a great impact on the appearance of trees, imagery of different seasons will be used to train the model.

Additionally, we will use the publicly available data set on every tree in the city of Vienna “Baumkataster” to train and test our model on exact tree locations [5].

## 1.3 Model

Former papers suggest that for image segmentation with satellite data the U-Net deep learning model is the most accurate for detecting objects, for example street detection [6] as well as crop field detection [7]. Furthermore, last year’s project also tried implementing a U-Net architecture but failed to yield promising results and this paper tries to build on that, especially because the data coaches also deem it a well-fitting model. This architecture will therefore also be used in this paper to predict tree locations.

The U-Net model is a special type of Convolutional Neural Network and consists of a contracting path and an expanding path. In the contracting path convolution and pooling layers are used to extract features from the original imagery, which in this project will consist of four pictures for each season and four color channels each as described above. The expanding path consists of the same structure of convolution and pooling layers but used in the other direction to up-sample the before contracted imagery [8]. As suggested in similar work this project will use skip connections between the expanding and contracting path as well as a temporal attention algorithm to prioritize more meaningful images [7]. The Binary Cross-Entropy loss between the predicted locations will be used and the actual locations from the “Baumkataster” will be split into a train and test set.

## 1.4 Project Scope and Possible Limitations

The model in this paper is trained only on satellite images of urban areas and therefore also only supposed to be used for tree detection within city environments. Also, the model focuses on tree detection in the temperate climate zone as this is the vegetation it is trained to observe. Further analysis on the impact of trees on, for example, heat regulation in cities and flooding prevention are out of the scope of this project and could be the topic of future research.

As this paper uses Sentinel-2 satellite images with 10-meter spatial resolution this could lead to issues as the images might not have a high enough resolution to detect trees reliably. Future work could therefore also focus on improving the image quality with better available satellite data.

## 2 BEAM

The figure below presents the BEAM representation [9] of the proposed tree detection system (see Figure 2), illustrating the data sources, training and inference processes, model architecture, evaluation pipeline, and associated risks.

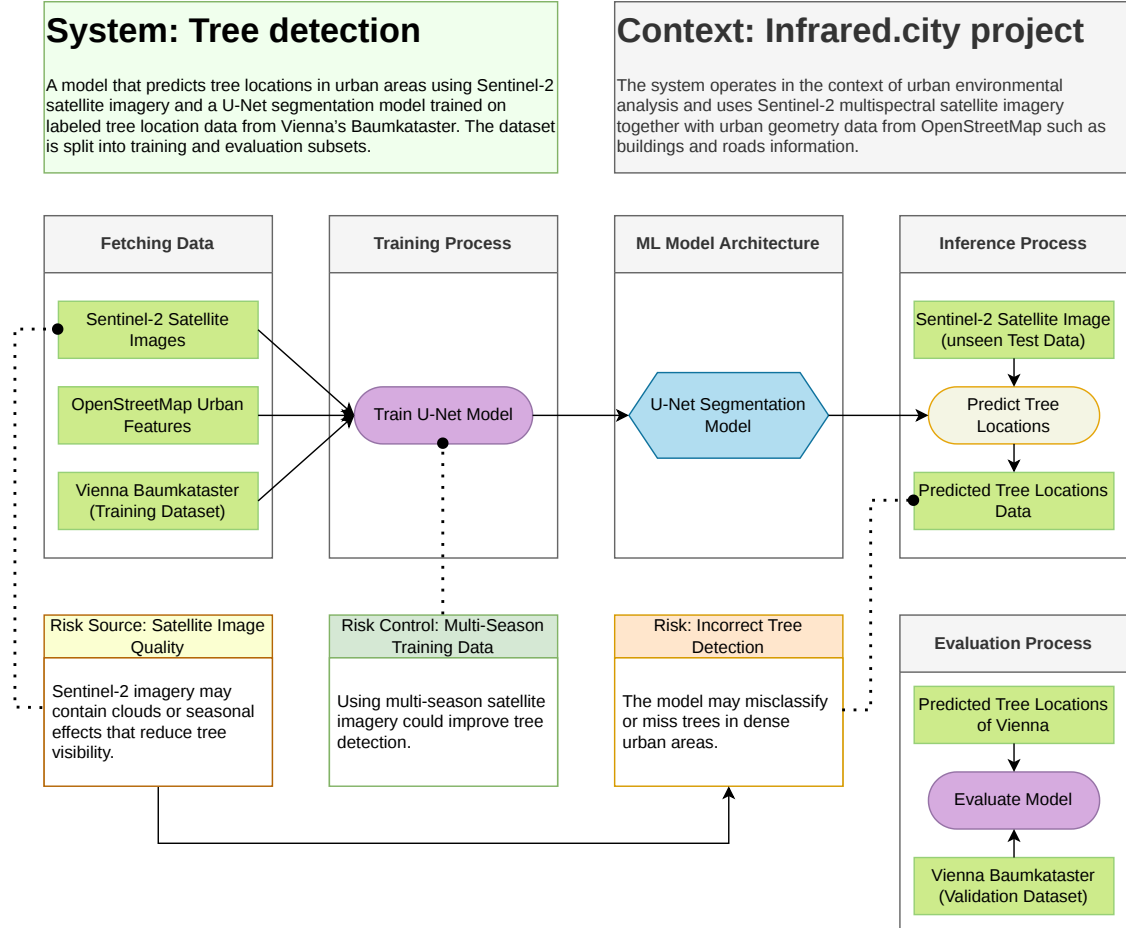


Figure 1: BEAM model of the proposed tree detection system.

### 3 Timeplan

The project will be conducted between March and June and is structured into several phases corresponding to the course milestones and deliverables.

#### 3.1 Phase 1: Project Setup & Planning

**March 9 – March 19**

This initial phase focuses on defining the project scope, exploring available data sources, and establishing a solid project plan.

- Tasks:**
- Kick-off session and first meeting with data coaches (March 9)
  - Define project objective and research question
  - Explore available datasets (Sentinel-2, OpenStreetMap, etc.)
  - Decide on modelling approach
  - Assign team roles
  - Draft project plan

**Deliverable:** Project Plan – March 19

#### 3.2 Phase 2: Methodology Development

**March 20 – March 29**

During this phase, the primary goal is to acquire the necessary data and establish the foundational methodology for feature extraction.

- Tasks:**
- Data collection and preprocessing
  - Feature extraction (spectral indices, vegetation signals)
  - Define modelling pipeline
  - Improve project plan based on feedback

**Deliverable:** Refined Project Plan – March 29

#### 3.3 Phase 3: Data Processing & Initial Modelling

**March 30 – April 21**

This period is dedicated to executing the data processing pipeline and training the first iteration of machine learning models.

- Tasks:**
- Implement data processing pipeline
  - Train initial machine learning models
  - Evaluate early results
  - Prepare intermediate analysis
  - Create presentation slides

**Deliverable:** Intermediate Report and Slides – April 21

### **3.4 Phase 4: Model Improvement & Validation**

**April 22 – June 6**

Focus now shifts towards optimizing model performance through rigorous validation, error analysis, and peer feedback.

- Tasks:**
- Intermediate consultations (April 22–24)
  - Improve model performance
  - Perform validation and error analysis
  - Conduct sparring group meetings
  - Prepare final report draft

**Deliverable:** Draft Final Report & Slides – June 7

### **3.5 Phase 5: Finalization & Presentation**

**June 8 – June 28**

The final phase encompasses the conclusive evaluation of the models and the preparation of the final deliverables and class presentations.

- Tasks:**
- Final model evaluation
  - Prepare final presentation
  - Final presentation in class (June 18–19)
  - Final report writing and revisions
  - Submit sparring group minutes

**Deliverables:**

- Final Report – June 28
- Sparring Group Minutes – June 28

## 4 Communication outline

This section describes the communication styles we are committed to use over the project.

### 4.1 Written communication

We will use two Teams in Microsoft Teams for our basic communication.

1. **DsLab26S\_infrared.city\_1**: This Team contains two channels for two different approaches. The **General** Channel is used as communication level with Kavita Surana (our connection to the Lecture and the WU). The other channel (**team intern**) is only accessible by the team itself and is our main chat for communication over the project.
2. **DsLab\_infrared.city\_1-coaches**: This Team is the basic for communication with the data coaches from infrared-city. We were asked to separate this from the main communication source, but still keep a Microsoft Teams Team for this. So we created a different Team.

### 4.2 Regular Meetings and Communication

Our meetings will be held via Microsoft Teams in most cases. It is possible that we are able to meet in person for one or another defined meeting. But regularly we plan to keep the communication remote or at least hybrid. We organized already two regular weekly meetings for basic communication.

1. **Regular Team Meeting**: On Thursdays 19:00 we will meet as a team remotely and talk about how to continue the work over the next week.
2. **Irregular Meetings with Kavita Surana**: In cases we need feedback for something from the WU site we schedule a meeting with her. To easily schedule the meeting we got a booking site for her time.
3. **Communication with Data Coaches from infrared.city**: No regular meeting is scheduled with the data coaches. Instead we write weekly reports in the shared Teams channel.

### 4.3 Documentation of Meetings

Because of the many meetings it is possible that one or another person is not able to participate every time. To still be able to communicate with absent people we want to write meeting notes and documentation of the meeting output after every meeting.

### 4.4 File and Code Repository

Every written result (documentation and project related) will be added to an already created GitHub repository. The repository is accessible by the team. See [https://github.com/nikmaster/wu\\_dslab\\_infrared-city](https://github.com/nikmaster/wu_dslab_infrared-city).

## 5 Team Roles

The main project team consists of 4 persons which are responsible for different focus points. But still commit to the project and in case one person gets stuck, the focus has to be to work together and find a way to tackle the issue.

| Person                      | Role                 | Tasks                                                        |
|-----------------------------|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Dominik Oberhumer</b>    | Organisation of Team | Preparation of Tools, Reminding of Deliverables and Timeplan |
| <b>Moritz Hörmansdorfer</b> | Data Scientist       | Machine Learning Training of Model                           |
| <b>Nina Salnikow</b>        | Data Engineer        | Fetching and Preparation of Data                             |
| <b>Sara Klasová</b>         | Data Scientist       | EDA (Exploratory Data Analysis)                              |

Besides these persons, we also have additional support from people which are related to the project:

1. **Kavita Surana:** is our supervisor from WU. She will help us regarding infrastructure and gives the needed points for grading at the university.
2. **Oana Taut** and **Vasiliki Fragkia** are our data coaches from infrared.city. They will support us with different approaches and sources how we can use the data to achieve our goal.



## 6 Literature

Following additional papers are planned to be used as sources:

1. A review of individual tree crown detection and delineation from optical remote sensing images [10]
2. Integrating Traditional and Deep Learning Methods to Detect Tree Crowns in Satellite Images [11]
3. A Sentinel-2 machine learning dataset for tree species classification in Germany [12]
4. Object-based classification of urban plant species from very high-resolution satellite imagery [13]
5. Improving Urban Tree Species Classification with High Resolution Satellite Imagery and Machine Learning [14]

## References

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- [14] R. Wenger, C. Bressant, L. Roettele, G. Forestier, and A. Puissant, “Improving urban tree species classification with high resolution satellite imagery and machine learning,” in *IEEE Conference Publication*, IEEE, 2024.